

Dear Lunenburg Community,

I'm writing to you today not just as your Superintendent, but as a partner in your child's education.

Budget season is fully underway. I know that talk about school funding can cause a lot of worry. You might be hearing different numbers and rumors, and it's completely natural to feel concerned about how this might impact your kids. I want to clear the air, share exactly where we stand, and invite you to sit at the table with us as we figure this out together.

Right now, we are looking at two different paths for next year. Let's look at what they mean in real numbers:

The first path is a "Restoration Budget" of \$28,454,840. I know that is a very large number. However, it is the amount necessary to provide our students with a solid, comprehensive education. It gives them the tools they need to grow into active citizens and successfully choose their own paths in life. This budget is actually a careful compromise—it sits right in the middle between a fully "needs-based" budget and a basic level service budget. Even with this compromise, this path currently leaves us with a shortfall of \$2,459,020.

The second path is a "Level Service Budget" of \$27,458,717. This budget simply keeps things exactly as they are right now, without adding anything new. The hard truth is that keeping things exactly the same will not meet the needs of our Lunenburg students. We know this based on both the quantitative data (like test scores) and qualitative data (like classroom feedback) we've been collecting this year. Furthermore, even with this bare-minimum approach, we are still looking at a deficit of \$1,462,897.

It is also important to share that these financial hurdles are not just a school problem. The initial town budget is facing a sizable deficit of \$1,170,561 as well. We are deeply aware of the needs of the Lunenburg community as a whole, not just the school district. Town and school leadership are truly working hand-in-hand. We share a vision that I like to conceptualize as "One Lunenburg-United."

I want to be completely transparent with you: the Town Manager, the School Committee, and I are doing absolutely everything in our power to protect our educators and staff by looking closely at how we run things behind the scenes to find savings first. However, with deficits of this magnitude across the school budget, and because we have already cut everything else we possibly could, we will unfortunately not be able to maintain our current staffing levels. We know that the people working in our schools are the heart of Lunenburg, which makes this an incredibly difficult reality to face.

I've had many people ask me a very fair question lately: *"We've had tight budgets before and always made it work. Why is this year so different? Are cuts really necessary?"*

It's true. In the past, we could rely on some financial "safety nets." We often received late grant money, or we were able to shift funds around from areas where we had budgeted a little extra just in case. This year, however, those safety nets are gone for two main reasons:

- **We've tightened our belts:** We've already trimmed our budget line items to run as efficiently as possible. While that's a good financial practice, it means we don't have any wiggle room left to absorb unexpected costs.
- **Annual federal entitlement grant money is drying up:** Both federal and state grants are shrinking. For instance, we've been told to expect a 30% drop in our Title I funding. Other grants are changing how they distribute money at the state level. Because of Lunenburg's size and economic profile, we likely won't qualify for the funds we used to. State funding is just highly unpredictable right now.

But please know we aren't just sitting back. We are turning over every stone to close this gap, and we've actually had some good news recently:

- **Health Insurance:** We initially braced for a massive 20% hike, but we've lowered that projection down to a 9% increase based on information from our insurance representative.
- **Supplies:** We planned for a 12% jump due to economic shifts, but things have settled down enough that we've safely lowered that estimate to a 6% increase.

We are making progress, but we really need your voices. The School Committee and I are working hard to prioritize what our schools need most. I would love for you to join us in this process. Whether you come to a meeting, send an email, or just stay informed and talk with your neighbors, your perspective as parents is incredibly powerful.

Let's stick together through these next few weeks. A team I admire recently shared a motto: *"We all we got... we all we need."* I truly believe that. Together, we are stronger, and together we will chart the best possible path forward for all of our Lunenburg students.